

BAPTISM IN THE COVENANT ARCHITECTURE

Why the Acts Accounts Vary and What That Variation Reveals

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Abstract

The baptism accounts of Acts have produced persistent theological controversy because they do not follow a uniform sequence. Spirit precedes water in some accounts, water precedes Spirit in others, Spirit comes through laying on of hands in one account, and in at least one case no water is involved at all. Most interpretive traditions resolve this variation by selecting one account as normative and treating the others as exceptional. This paper argues that the variation is not a problem requiring resolution. It is the data.

The paper reads the baptism accounts through the covenant architecture of Acts, which is not primarily a church history but a narrative of the covenant being extended outward through concentric geographic and covenant-identity boundaries: Jerusalem, Judea, Samaria, and the ends of the earth. Each major baptism account occurs at one of those boundary crossings, and the specific sequence in each account is determined by the covenant-identity context of the recipients and the specific theological argument being made at that boundary.

The paper also addresses two cases that have been used to argue against the necessity of water baptism: the thief at the stake (Luke 23:43) and the household of Cornelius (Acts 10). In both cases the architecture provides a precise explanation that strengthens rather than weakens the covenantal significance of baptism. The conclusion is that baptism is a genuine covenant threshold event whose mode, sequence, and administration vary contextually but whose function as the formal water-crossing ratification of a covenant transition is consistent across the canon.

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SECTION 1 THE PROBLEM: WHY THE ACCOUNTS VARY

Section 1: The Problem

The baptism accounts in the New Testament do not follow a single uniform sequence. This has produced genuine theological controversy across Christian traditions, each of which tends to select one sequence as normative and treat the others as special cases or exceptions.

Account	Covenant context	Sequence
Acts 2:38 Shavuot crowd	Jewish diaspora at the covenant formalization feast	Repentance, water baptism in the name of Yahusha, then receive the Spirit
Acts 8:12-17 Samaria	Half-Jewish, half-Gentile community with a competing covenant history	Belief, water baptism, then Spirit through apostolic laying on of hands
Acts 8:36-38 Ethiopian eunuch	Gentile God-fearer reading Isaiah, excluded under Deuteronomy 23:1	Belief in Yahusha, immediate water baptism, no laying on of hands mentioned
Acts 9:17-18 Paul	Torah-trained Jew, Damascus road calling	Laying on of hands by Ananias, scales fall, water baptism, then strengthened
Acts 10:44-48 Cornelius	First fully Gentile household, Roman centurion, uncircumcised God-fearer	Spirit falls while Peter is still speaking, then water baptism as formal ratification
Acts 16:14-15 Lydia	Gentile God-fearer, seller of purple	Yahuah opens her heart, she and her household are baptized, no specific Spirit mention
Acts 16:30-33 Philippian jailer	Gentile, no prior covenant connection	Believes, immediate water baptism in the middle of the night
Acts 19:1-6 Ephesian disciples	Jews with only John's baptism	Re-baptized in Yahusha's name, then Paul lays hands, Spirit comes
Luke 23:43 Thief at the stake	Dying Jew, no water available, direct encounter with Yahusha	Covenant confession, Yahusha pronounces a direct verdict: today you will be with me in paradise

The standard responses to this variation are unsatisfying. The cessationist tradition tends to make Acts 2:38 normative and treat Cornelius as an exceptional sovereign act. The charismatic tradition tends to make Cornelius normative and treat Acts 2:38 as a transitional account. Both move too quickly from the variation to a resolution.

The variation is not a problem requiring a preferred account. It is the data. Reading it correctly requires understanding what Acts is structurally doing, what covenant context each account is operating within, and what architectural argument each sequence is making. When those three questions are answered for each account, the variation resolves itself into a coherent pattern.

Section 2: The Canonical Foundation

Baptism does not appear in the New Testament without a canonical context. The water-threshold event is one of the most structurally consistent patterns in the entire Hebrew covenant framework. Understanding baptism requires reading it inside that pattern.

2.1 The Fourfold Water-Crossing Pattern

The covenant architecture of the Hebrew Scriptures contains a fourfold water-crossing sequence that runs from Genesis to Revelation. Each event follows the same structural pattern: chaos, boundary, crossing, covenant renewal. Each operates at a different scale.

Event	Water	Scale	Covenant function
Noah's Flood	The floodwaters	Covenant world	Judgment of the corrupt covenant world, preservation of the covenant line through the water, new covenant established on the other side
Reed Sea Crossing	Yam Suph (Reed Sea)	National	Judgment on Egypt at the boundary water, covenant people pass through as a consecration event, covenant formalized at Sinai on the other side
Jordan Crossing	The Jordan River	Territorial	Entry into covenant inheritance, covenant renewal at Gilgal, territorial possession begins on the other side
Sea of Glass	Revelation 15	Cosmic/eschatological	Final judgment, remnant standing on the sea that has been passed through, covenant completed at cosmic scale

Paul makes the Reed Sea crossing explicit in 1 Corinthians 10:1-2: our fathers were all under the cloud, and all passed through the sea, and all were baptized into Moses in the cloud and in the sea. He names the Reed Sea crossing a baptism. This is not a metaphor. It is a structural identification: the Reed Sea crossing and water baptism are the same kind of covenant event at different scales.

1 Peter 3:20-21 makes the same identification with the flood: the flood saved eight people through water. Baptism, which corresponds to this, now saves you. The Greek word is *antitupon*, a structural correspondence. Noah's flood and water baptism correspond to each other as the same covenant-threshold event at different scales.

2.2 What a Water-Crossing Does in the Covenant Framework

Across the fourfold canonical pattern, every water-crossing event does the same three things simultaneously:

Function	Description	Canonical evidence
Separates	The water marks the boundary between the old covenant state and the new one. What is on the far side is judged, left behind, or ended.	Egypt is judged at the Reed Sea. The old world is destroyed in the flood. The wilderness is left behind at the Jordan.
Consecrates	The act of passing through the water marks the covenant people as set apart from the world they left. It is a threshold consecration.	Israel passing through Yam Suph is the Temple Pattern consecration sequence: unconsecrated outer world, boundary water, set-apart people moving toward presence.
Ratifies	The crossing formally enacts the covenant transition that has occurred or is occurring. It is the public covenant-legal instrument of the change of state.	The Jordan crossing formally enacts Israel's entry into covenant inheritance. The mikveh in Jewish practice formally enacts changes of status. Romans 6:3-4 names water baptism as the formal enactment of death and resurrection.

2.3 The Mikveh Precedent

The mikveh, the ritual immersion pool used throughout Second Temple Jewish practice, is the direct institutional predecessor of water baptism. It was used for the formal ratification of covenant status changes: proselyte conversion, priestly purification before Temple service, return from impurity. The mikveh was not a one-time event in most cases. It was a covenant-legal instrument used whenever a formal change of covenant status needed to be publicly enacted.

John's baptism and the subsequent covenant baptism both stand in this tradition. They are water-crossing events that formally ratify covenant transitions. The specific transition being ratified differs. The architectural function is the same.

SECTION 3 JOHN'S BAPTISM AND YAHUSHA'S BAPTISM: TWO DISTINCT CATEGORIES

Section 3: Two Distinct Categories

One of the clearest architectural distinctions in the baptism accounts is that John's baptism and the covenant baptism in Yahusha's name are not the same event at different stages. They are two categorically different events with different functions.

Category	John's baptism	Covenant baptism in Yahusha's name
Moedim function	Preparation and threshold event. John's ministry is explicitly positioned as the voice of one calling in the wilderness, preparing the way. It is the Moedim threshold before the covenant fulfillment arrives.	Covenant formalization. The ratification of covenant entry into the community established by Yahusha's death, burial, and resurrection. It is the Moedim event of the new covenant era.
What it points to	John says explicitly: I baptize you with water for repentance. But he who is coming after me is mightier than I. He will baptize you with the Spirit and fire (Matthew 3:11). John's baptism points forward to something that has not yet arrived.	Ratifies the covenant transition that Yahusha's work accomplished. It does not point forward. It enacts backward: the death and resurrection already completed are formally participated in.
Romans 6 language	Not applicable. Romans 6 does not describe John's baptism.	Do you not know that all of us who have been baptized into Yahusha the Messiah were baptized into his death? We were buried therefore with him by baptism into death, in order that, just as Yahusha was raised from the dead, so we too might walk in newness of life (Romans 6:3-4). This is the burial-resurrection covenant ratification language.
Acts 19 confirmation	Paul encounters twelve disciples in Ephesus who received only John's baptism and do not know of the Spirit. Paul re-baptizes them in Yahusha's name. John's baptism does not function as covenant baptism.	After re-baptism in Yahusha's name and Paul's laying on of hands, the Spirit comes. The two baptisms are not interchangeable.

Yahusha's own baptism at the Jordan is in a third category. It is neither John's preparation baptism nor the covenant entry baptism of believers. It is a covenant inauguration event: the commissioning of the covenant fulfiller. The Spirit descends, the voice speaks, the ministry begins. This establishes the pattern but is not itself the model for believer baptism.

SECTION 4 THE ACTS BOUNDARY STRUCTURE

Section 4: The Acts Boundary Structure

Acts is not primarily a church history. It is a narrative of the covenant being extended outward through concentric geographic and covenant-identity boundaries. Acts 1:8 states this structure explicitly: you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the ends of the earth.

Boundary	Covenant-identity description	Primary baptism account
Jerusalem	The center. Torah-observant Jews at the covenant formation feast of Shavuot. The diaspora Jews who have maintained covenant connection. These are people already within the covenant framework of Israel.	Acts 2:38 Shavuot crowd. The founding event of the covenant community. The sequence here (repentance, water, Spirit) establishes the baseline.
Judea	The Jewish homeland. Torah-observant Jews with full covenant standing, geographically connected to Jerusalem.	No distinct baptism account. The Judean mission is the background movement through which the scattered community carries the same covenant baseline established at Acts 2. Judea operates on the Jerusalem precedent without architectural variation because no new covenant-identity boundary is being crossed.
Samaria	The contested threshold. Samaritans are half-Jewish by historical origin (Assyrian resettlement, 2 Kings 17), claim descent from Joseph and Ephraim, have their own Torah and worship site at Mount Gerizim, and are separated from full Jewish covenant standing. They are neither fully inside the Jewish covenant nor fully outside it.	Acts 8:12-17 Philip baptizes, apostles come to confirm. The most complex sequence, requiring Jerusalem apostolic presence.
Ethiopia / end of the known world (south)	A Gentile God-fearer from the extreme south. Reading Isaiah, already drawn to the covenant but excluded from the assembly by Deuteronomy 23:1.	Acts 8:36-38 the Ethiopian eunuch. Immediate baptism, no apostolic presence, no laying on of hands.
Damascus / Jewish diaspora	A Torah-trained Pharisee receiving a direct calling.	Acts 9:17-18 Paul. Laying on of hands precedes water.
Gentile world (first fully Gentile household)	A Roman centurion with no covenant connection by birth. A God-fearer but uncircumcised. The first crossing of the full Gentile boundary.	Acts 10:44-48 Cornelius. Spirit before water. The architectural hinge of the entire book.
Europe / ends of the earth (west)	Gentiles with no prior covenant connection at all.	Acts 16:14-15 (Lydia) and Acts 16:30-33 (jailer). Direct, immediate, no extended sequence.

Every major baptism account in Acts occurs at a specific covenant-identity boundary crossing. The sequence in each account is not random variation. It is the architectural argument being made at that specific boundary.

Section 5: The Accounts Analyzed

ACCOUNT 1 Acts 2:38 The Shavuot Crowd

Context: Jewish diaspora, gathered in Jerusalem for Shavuot. Devout men from every nation under heaven (Acts 2:5). These are people already within the covenant framework of Israel, present at the covenant calendar's most architecturally significant feast.

Shavuot is the Moedim feast of covenant formalization. The Torah was given at Sinai on Shavuot. The new covenant community is formally established on Shavuot. This is not coincidental. It is Moedim precision: the appointed time for covenant formalization in the old covenant is the appointed time for covenant formalization in the new covenant.

Sequence analysis: Peter says repent, be baptized in the name of Yahusha the Messiah for the forgiveness of your sins, and you will receive the gift of the Spirit.

The sequence is repentance (covenant reorientation), water (formal threshold crossing and public covenant declaration), then Spirit (covenant presence received). This is the baseline sequence for Jews already within the covenant framework who are now entering the new covenant community.

Why this sequence: these are covenant-knowledgeable people who understand the covenant legal framework. The water-then-Spirit sequence is the formal covenant ratification followed by the covenant presence. There is no ambiguity about their inclusion that requires a prior Spirit demonstration.

ACCOUNT 2 Acts 8:12-17 Samaria

Context: Samaritans. Their covenant status is the most architecturally complex of all the Acts accounts. They have Torah. They have covenant history. They worship Yahuah. But they are historically separated from the Jerusalem covenant community and have a competing worship site and a competing covenant claim.

Sequence analysis: Philip baptizes them. The Spirit does not come. Peter and John travel from Jerusalem, lay hands on them, and then the Spirit comes.

Why this sequence: the Samaritan inclusion required apostolic confirmation from Jerusalem because Samaria was the contested boundary. Without the personal presence of Jerusalem apostles confirming the inclusion, the Samaritan baptism could have been read as the establishment of a separate covenant branch, parallel to but disconnected from the Jerusalem community. The laying on of hands by Peter and John is the formal covenant-legal connection: the Samaritan community is confirmed as genuinely connected to the same covenant root, not a separate tree.

The Spirit's delay is not a sign that something went wrong with Philip's ministry or the Samaritans' faith. It is the architecture holding the covenant community together at its most contested internal boundary.

The Spirit waits for the formal apostolic confirmation because the architectural stakes at the Samaritan boundary are highest.

ACCOUNT 3 Acts 8:36-38 The Ethiopian Eunuch

Context: An Ethiopian court official, a eunuch, a God-fearer reading Isaiah 53 in his chariot. Two architectural details matter. First, he is a Gentile. Second, he is a eunuch, a condition that under Deuteronomy 23:1 explicitly excluded him from the assembly of Israel.

Philip has just explained Isaiah 53 to him. The passage the man was reading when Philip arrived is the servant suffering passage. But the text immediately before and after Isaiah 53 in the scroll is Isaiah 52 and 54. And Isaiah 56:3-5 contains the specific reversal of Deuteronomy 23:1: let not the eunuch say I am a dry tree. For thus says Yahuah: to the eunuchs who keep my Sabbaths, who choose the things that please me and hold fast my covenant, I will give in my house and within my walls a monument and a name better than sons and daughters.

Sequence analysis: Philip explains, the man believes, sees water by the road, asks what prevents him from being baptized, is immediately baptized. No apostolic presence. No laying on of hands. Immediate.

Why this sequence: Isaiah 56 had already declared his inclusion. Philip explained the passage containing that reversal. No Jerusalem apostolic confirmation was required because the prophetic text had already resolved the inclusion question. Where the text has already answered whether a person belongs to the covenant, the narrative does not require a separate apostolic confirmation step. Philip baptizes immediately because there is no contested boundary requiring formal community ratification. The prophetic text had crossed it before Philip arrived.

ACCOUNT 4 Acts 9:17-18 Paul

Context: A Torah-trained Pharisee from the tribe of Benjamin, trained under Gamaliel, who has been persecuting the covenant community. He receives a direct calling on the Damascus road but arrives in Damascus blind, fasting, and waiting.

Sequence analysis: Ananias lays hands on Paul, his sight is restored, he rises and is baptized, then eats and is strengthened.

Why this sequence: Paul's case is architecturally distinct from every other account. His covenant transition was initiated on the Damascus road by direct encounter with Yahusha. But that encounter left him blind, silent, and isolated in Damascus for three days. The laying on of hands by Ananias is not primarily a healing act. It is a formal covenant-community connection: a named member of the community (Acts 9:10-17 identifies Ananias by name and location) is sent to confirm that the former persecutor is now a covenant brother. The Damascus community receives Paul before the water comes.

This sequence makes a specific architectural point: the covenant transition that began on the road is formally completed through the community, not independently. Paul does not self-administer his

baptism. He receives it from the community he was sent to join. The sequence demonstrates that covenant entry is community-mediated even when the initiating event was a direct sovereign encounter.

ACCOUNT 5 Acts 10:44-48 Cornelius

Context: A Roman centurion. Uncircumcised. A God-fearer who prays and gives alms. The first fully Gentile household in Acts. This is the architectural hinge of the entire book.

Sequence analysis: Peter is still speaking when the Spirit falls on everyone listening. The Jewish believers who came with Peter are astonished that the gift of the Spirit was poured out even on the Gentiles. Peter says: can anyone withhold water for baptizing these people who have received the Spirit just as we have? They are then baptized in the name of Yahusha the Messiah.

Why this sequence: this is the most architecturally significant account in Acts and it requires precise reading. The Spirit's arrival before the water is not a disorder in the ceremony. It is the sovereign architectural argument that Yahuah makes at the full Gentile boundary.

The architectural weight of the Cornelius account begins before the baptism. In Acts 10:9-16, Peter receives a vision of unclean animals and a command to eat. He refuses. The vision comes a second time. He refuses again. It comes a third time. Three repetitions of the same vision. In covenant architecture, triple repetition is the signal of a definitive divine verdict that overrides human objection. This is not gentle suggestion. It is the covenant-legal pressure of a judgment being delivered to a resistant party.

Then the men from Cornelius arrive. Then the Spirit tells Peter explicitly to go with them without hesitation. Then Peter enters the house and the Spirit falls before he can manage the situation or apply any gatekeeping logic. The sequence is structured to prevent any human override of the boundary crossing: Yahuah removes Peter's objection through the triple vision, sends the men, commands Peter to go, and completes the covenant transaction before Peter can finish his speech.

The Jewish covenant community at this point has not resolved whether Gentiles can be included without circumcision. The question is not just administrative. It is architectural: does the covenant extend to uncircumcised Gentiles? Yahuah answers that question before Peter finishes speaking by demonstrating the same Spirit that fell at Shavuot falling on uncircumcised Gentiles.

The Spirit's arrival before the water is Yahuah making the architectural decision visible and irrefutable. The water baptism that follows is Peter's formal ratification of what Yahuah already did. His argument for the water is covenant-legal: who can withhold the formal covenant-legal instrument from those on whom Yahuah has already acted? Peter argues for the water. He does not argue that water is now unnecessary.

Cornelius proves that the covenant transaction and the covenant ratification instrument are not the same thing. Yahuah enacts the transaction. The water formally ratifies it. At the full Gentile boundary, Yahuah makes the transaction visible before the instrument is applied so that no one in the Jewish covenant community can argue the inclusion did not happen.

ACCOUNT 6 Acts 16:14-15 Lydia and Acts 16:30-33 The Philippian Jailer

Context: Both accounts are in Philippi, a Roman colony, in the Gentile world beyond the Cornelius boundary that was established in Acts 10.

Lydia is a Gentile God-fearer. Yahuah opens her heart. She and her household are baptized. No specific Spirit sequence is mentioned. No apostolic confirmation is required.

The jailer has no prior covenant connection. He believes and is baptized immediately in the middle of the night. No waiting, no laying on of hands, no apostolic delegation.

Why these sequences: Acts 10 established the architectural precedent for the full Gentile inclusion. The Cornelius account was the foundational demonstration. All subsequent Gentile baptisms in Acts do not need to repeat the Cornelius argument. The boundary was crossed at Cornelius's house. Every Gentile baptism after that stands on the architectural ground that Acts 10 established.

The directness and immediacy of these accounts is architecturally appropriate. The question of Gentile inclusion has been resolved. The instrument is applied without the extended demonstration that the first Gentile boundary crossing required.

ACCOUNT 7 Acts 19:1-6 The Ephesian Disciples

Context: Twelve disciples in Ephesus who received John's baptism and have not heard of the Spirit.

Sequence analysis: Paul asks if they received the Spirit when they believed. They say they have not heard of the Spirit. Paul asks what baptism they received. They say John's. Paul explains that John's baptism was preparation pointing toward Yahusha. They are re-baptized in Yahusha's name. Paul lays hands. The Spirit comes. They speak in tongues and prophesy.

Why this sequence: this is the clearest account demonstrating that John's baptism and covenant baptism are categorically different. These are already-baptized, already-believing people. John's baptism was a genuine and valid covenant event in its own category: the threshold preparation for the covenant fulfiller's arrival. But once the fulfillment arrived, the preparation-baptism was replaced by the covenant-ratification-baptism. These disciples were in an architecturally incomplete position: they had received the threshold event without the covenant reality it pointed to.

Re-baptism in Yahusha's name is not a correction of an error. It is the completion of the covenant transition that John's baptism anticipated. The laying on of hands and the Spirit following confirm that the full covenant transaction is now complete.

Section 6: The Thief at the Stake and the Cornelius Sequence

Two cases are consistently cited in debates about baptism as evidence against its covenantal necessity. Both require careful architectural reading.

6.1 The Thief at the Stake (Luke 23:43)

The text: One of the men crucified alongside Yahusha says: remember me when you come into your kingdom. Yahusha responds: truly I say to you, today you will be with me in paradise.

The architectural reading: across the Gospel healing accounts, Yahusha does not operate as a participant petitioning the covenant architecture. He commands it directly. Elijah and Elisha prayed and Yahuah acted. Yahusha says be clean, rise and walk, come out, and the covenant architecture responds without intermediary. This is the structural distinction between a prophet who petitions and the one who holds the authority the architecture was built around. The healing accounts confirm this pattern consistently: Yahusha commands, the architecture responds.

Water baptism is the formal covenant-legal instrument by which the threshold crossing is publicly ratified. It is the instrument established within the covenant framework for this purpose. Like all covenant-legal instruments, it derives its significance from the authority that established it.

When the authority who established the instrument is directly present on the execution stake pronouncing the verdict personally, the instrument is not bypassed or rendered irrelevant. It is subsumed into the direct act of the authority from whom it derives its significance in the first place. Yahusha is not making an exception to baptism. He is doing what only he can do: pronouncing the covenant verdict directly as the one who holds the authority the water event points back to.

This is architecturally consistent, not inconsistent. The instrument matters because of the authority it represents. When that authority is present and acting directly, the representation is not needed. This is the same logic by which the Temple sacrifices were complete before Yahusha's death and were not required afterward: the reality to which they pointed arrived.

The thief does not prove that water baptism is optional. He proves that Yahusha holds the authority the water baptism instrument was established to represent. The instrument matters because of that authority. When the authority acts directly, the instrument is subsumed into the act.

6.2 The Cornelius Sequence (Acts 10:44-48)

The Cornelius account is sometimes read as evidence that water baptism is secondary or optional because the Spirit arrived before the water. Section 5 addressed this in detail, but the architectural summary is worth stating precisely.

The Cornelius account does not teach that water baptism is optional. It teaches the distinction between the covenant transaction and the covenant-legal instrument that formally ratifies it. Yahuah enacted the transaction. Peter administered the instrument. Both happened. The order was determined by the architectural need at the full Gentile boundary: Yahuah made the sovereign decision visible before any human administrator could object that the Gentiles were not eligible.

Peter's response confirms this. He does not say: since Yahuah has already acted, water is unnecessary. He says: who can withhold water from these people who have received the Spirit just as we have? Peter is arguing for the water. The Spirit's prior arrival is his argument for why the water must be given, not why it can be omitted.

The Cornelius account strengthens the covenantal significance of water baptism rather than undermining it. It demonstrates that the water is the formal covenant-legal ratification of the threshold crossing, important enough that Peter argues for it even when the sovereign transaction has visibly preceded it.

Section 7: The Mode Question

The debate over baptismal mode (immersion versus sprinkling versus pouring) is often conducted at the level of lexical argument: baptizo means to immerse, therefore immersion is the correct mode. That argument is correct but it does not go deep enough. The mode question has an architectural answer that is stronger than the lexical one.

Romans 6:3-4 is the primary architectural text: do you not know that all of us who have been baptized into Yahusha the Messiah were baptized into his death? We were buried therefore with him by baptism into death, in order that, just as Yahusha was raised from the dead, we too might walk in newness of life.

Paul is using the burial-and-resurrection language of the Eden Arc layer. The old covenant state is buried. The new covenant state is entered through resurrection. This is the same layer that governs the water-crossing pattern in the Hebrew Scriptures: death of the old, passage through the boundary, new life on the other side.

Architectural layer	Immersion	Sprinkling or pouring
Eden Arc burial and resurrection	Full immersion enacts the burial-resurrection architecture precisely: the person goes under (death and burial), comes up (resurrection and new life). The body performs the covenant-legal event the architecture describes.	Sprinkling and pouring do not enact the burial-resurrection architecture. They apply water to the surface without the under-and-up movement that the Eden Arc language requires.
Water-crossing pattern	Full immersion matches the Reed Sea and Jordan crossing patterns: going through the water, not having water applied. The crossing is a full passage, not a touching.	Sprinkling and pouring do not match the crossing pattern. Israel did not have water sprinkled on them at the Reed Sea. They passed through it.
Mikveh precedent	The mikveh requires full immersion. The body goes entirely under the water. This is the established Jewish covenant-legal practice from which water baptism derives.	The mikveh does not permit sprinkling or pouring as valid immersion forms.

The architectural conclusion on mode is not merely that immersion is preferred or more symbolic. It is that immersion is the mode that enacts the covenant-legal event the architecture describes. The other modes do not enact that event. They apply water without performing the covenant action.

Note: This is a strong architectural argument for immersion. It does not resolve every pastoral question about mode in cases of physical limitation or extreme circumstance. The architecture grounds the principle. Pastoral application in edge cases requires the same contextual discernment the Acts accounts themselves model.

Section 8: Conclusion

The baptism accounts of Acts vary because they were designed to vary. Each account is doing specific architectural work at a specific covenant-identity boundary. Reading them as a collection of evidence for or against a single normative sequence misses what they are collectively demonstrating.

8.1 What the Variation Demonstrates

The Acts accounts collectively demonstrate that the covenant being extended through the book has a specific architecture: it moves from Jerusalem outward through concentric covenant-identity boundaries, and at each boundary the baptism account makes a specific architectural argument appropriate to that boundary.

At the Jewish diaspora boundary (Acts 2), the baseline sequence establishes the norm for those already within the covenant framework entering the new covenant community. At the Samaritan boundary (Acts 8), the apostolic confirmation holds the covenant community together at its most contested internal division. At the Ethiopian boundary (Acts 8), the prophetic text's prior declaration of inclusion removes the need for apostolic confirmation. At the full Gentile boundary (Acts 10), Yahuah's sovereign act before the water makes the architectural argument that no Jewish objection can override.

8.2 What Remains Constant Across All the Variation

Across all the variation, three things remain constant. First, water baptism is always present or explicitly argued for in every account except the thief, whose case is explained by Yahusha's direct operational authority over the covenant architecture. Water is never simply omitted.

Second, the covenant transition being ratified is always the same: from the old covenant state to the new covenant community established through Yahusha's death, burial, and resurrection. The threshold crossed is always the same threshold.

Third, the mode that fits the architecture is immersion, because the burial-and-resurrection language of Romans 6 and the crossing-through pattern of the canonical water events both require the under-and-up movement that immersion performs.

8.3 The Synthesis

Baptism is a genuine covenant threshold event with real architectural significance. It is the formal water-crossing that publicly ratifies a covenant transition. Its mode matters because the architecture requires the burial-resurrection movement. Its sequence varies because the covenant-identity context of the recipients and the specific boundary being crossed determine what architectural argument needs to be made at each moment.

It is not optional in the sense that the canonical water-crossing events are not optional. Israel did not cross the Jordan as a symbol. The mikveh was not a suggestion. Romans 6 does not describe a spiritual metaphor. The formal ratification of a covenant transition is a covenant-legal act with covenant-legal weight.

But the variation in the Acts accounts is the text's own demonstration that the formal instrument serves the covenant transaction, not the reverse. When Yahuah enacts the transaction at Cornelius's house before the instrument is applied, he is not dismissing the instrument. He is demonstrating what the instrument represents, so that the instrument can be given without objection to those on whom he has already acted.

The distinction between transaction and instrument does not make the instrument dispensable in normal covenant-community circumstances. The covenant threshold event requires the public formal ratification that the water-crossing provides. Cornelius received the water. The Shavuot crowd received the water. The eunuch asked for the water. The jailer received the water immediately. The instrument is not the mechanism of covenant inclusion, but it is the required public ratification of that inclusion in every account where the one who holds direct authority over the architecture is not personally present pronouncing the verdict.

The governing statement of this paper:

Baptism is the formal water-crossing event that publicly ratifies a covenant transition.

Its mode is immersion because the burial-resurrection architecture of Romans 6 and the canonical water-crossing pattern both require the under-and-up movement.

Its sequence varies in Acts because each account is making a specific architectural argument at a specific covenant-identity boundary.

The variation is not the problem. It is the data.

When the data is read through the covenant architecture of Acts 1:8 — Jerusalem, Judea, Samaria, ends of the earth — every account is coherent, every sequence is explained, and the thief's case resolves not as an exception but as the architecture recognizing the authority it was built around.